second floor, replete with three lively restaurants, a pub and an ultra-modern cocktail bar, boasted a combined capacity of 800 indoor and terrace seats. There was even gold-rimmed crockery, but it was quickly discovered that the plates weren't dishwasher-safe, so they ended up in the basement and were only taken out for special events.

When opening day arrived after thirty-two months of construction, Honecker celebrated 'a house of the people' which, he said, testified to the GDR's socialist national culture. 'The Palace of the Republic will become a venue of living political, spiritual and cultural life, both for the citizens of the capital and for all the working people of our Socialist Republic'.9

With this auspicious start, Honecker also forged ahead with other major town planning projects for Berlin, including completing Marx-Engels Platz; and transforming Friedrichstraße into a bustling shopping district. Work also started on renovating the Platz der Akademie to its historic form, the restoration of Charité University and work on Karl-Liebknecht-Straße, Rathausstraße and the wide, windy intersection at Alexanderplatz. 'These objectives,' Honecker stated, 'aimed at raising cultural and material living standards,' and would spur Berliners to 'greater efforts to strengthen their fatherland, our socialist GDR.'10 Over time, in contrast to Ulbricht's efforts at sweeping away Berlin's imperial past, renovation projects expanded. 'Literally rising from the ruins, Berlin today is increasingly becoming a symbol of the triumphant advance of socialism on German soil,' Honecker gushed, as work started on restoring the Zughaus, Gendarmenmarkt, Konzerthaus and neighbouring stone and granite churches, which returned to their pre-war grandeur.11 'The fine restorations,' observed British writer Anthony Read, 'stood out like new teeth in a mouth full of decay. Between and around them the ugly gaps of bombed sites remained, flanked by buildings still bearing the scars of war, their facades pot marked and cratered by thousands of bullets, shells and shrapnel fragments.'12

Among the greatest pleasures of Honecker's duties were the opportunities to welcome foreign dignitaries to Berlin. When Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi became the first world leader to enjoy the splendour of the new Palace of the Republic at a lavish banquet in July 1976, the American Ambassador remembered 'the biggest publicity splash in recent memory'.